

credit card at the next statement date and your rate would be lower. Another horrible product in a similar vein is the tax refund anticipation loan.

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6. Any financial product you do not fully understand
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Any financial product could be a potential disaster if you do not understand how it works and how it benefits you. For example, a lot of the current sob stories relating to foreclosures involve borrowers who did not understand how their mortgages worked. All they saw was their initial mortgage payment and did not understand how the payments would adjust.

The lesson here is that before you lay your money on the line for any financial product, you must research it and read the fine print. If you do not do your due diligence, a product that is potentially beneficial to others could be a nightmare to you. — **Xin Lu**



The Best and Worst Places to Stash Cash in Your Home

The current economy has many people considering a simpler method of financial security—cold, hard cash. And while we all agree that a buck has value, it is also a bit vulnerable when not hidden properly. Forget the \$3,000 high-tech safe, and stick with these affordable tricks I picked up. You'll never guess which way I'm using to hide my money!

TAMPON BOX

I'm not kidding. WalletPop.com mentioned this gem of a tip years ago, and I was instantly intrigued. By leaving a little "product" in the box for authenticity, and taping a wad of cash to the inside, you can be sure a robber won't think to look in there. (Ladies can be certain that a husband or boyfriend won't find it, either.)